FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

In 2023, the buzzword one heard most often in public was Artificial Intelligence. The amazing things it could do and how it would change our lives for better or worse. The world has not seemed quite the same ever since ChatGPT arrived on humanity's shores some 13 months ago. Its reception was filtered through the old fantasy that produced equal fascination and dread. Everyone's imagination went towards a machine that could paint like Picasso, write like Dickens, compose like Bach, discover penicillin and decode cosmic secrets like dark matter, not to speak of more humdrum tasks like playing better chess than Kasparov or writing code. In short, a god-like superhuman or a thinking Frankenstein's monster.

Gross overestimation or understatement? It doesn't matter. The question that springs immediately to mind is, what can it really do? How can it transform lives in a country like India, where centuries coexist and the future lives along with the past? The discoveries didn't take long coming. By January 2023, within a month, this new plaything had attracted some 100 million users. The year thereafter rolled by like a series of explosions in real-life applications of AI, across domains mundane and superspecialised, both to make the world a better place and to make war. As it closed, we saw PM Narendra Modi's speech at the Kashi Tamil Sangamam being translated in real-time. A task that looks beguilingly simple but requires something as complex as cracking the human genome code.

Clearly, we could be living through Ver. 2.0 of the Copernican revolution. And it falls upon us to not just marvel at the next use-case in aspects of shock and awe but to seek to understand the paradigm as it evolves. Remember, humankind's first tech revolution came not with knowing what fire could do, but with knowing how to control and master it. This New Year's special issue, bookending what promises to be an exciting year, we roll out for you a series of essays from the best minds in the game: from global and Indian industry leaders to top government figures like Rajeev Chandrasekhar, who speaks with domain familiarity, to use-case specialists and critics. Think of it like a travel guide to an unexplored continent. That's for the uninitiated, which is most of us. Those already past the initiation rites too will find rich food for thought, and an index to how the top brains in the world and India are thinking about AI.



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You will observe a few recurring leitmotifs in the essays. One relates to AI's transformative potential across walks of life. In the complex mosaic that is India, it puts communication on steroids. As Google CEO Sundar Pichai writes, people across the country are already using the conversational AI interface Bard "in nine different Indian languages". That's just the beginning. Google is working with the Indian government "to collate and open-source speech data for almost 800 dialects"—its research team in Bengaluru will finally fashion "a unified model that can handle over 100 different Indian languages". The content of all that communication has the potential to rewrite our future. Many writers have cited the amazing possibilities such as screening for eye disease, detecting tuberculosis and discovering antibodies. AI can also be used to assess crop health, predict floods, revolutionise education, massively boost the start-up economy, reshape productivity within existing industries, and much more. Changing everything from warfare to election campaigning. Most of it exudes a mood of technological optimism. As when G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant projects an "incredible $967 billion" flowing into the Indian economy by 2035. Or when Microsoft India and South Asia president Puneet Chandok evokes India's "billion scale impact", especially with Stanford University's AI Index Report affirming that we have the "largest AI talent concentration" in the world. That, along with something like India Stack and India Datasets, among the world's largest sets of Big Data, gives us the chance to aim for world leadership in this field. But as we think of autonomous military-grade weapons, deepfakes, self-driven car crashes and sentiment analysis feeding election manipulation, a sense of foreboding arises naturally, at least to a degree commensurate with the excitement.

This forms the second recurring motif for all our essayists: an awareness of the risks. From Pichai onwards, everyone flags the sense of ethical responsibility that must accompany innovation. We find even interesting contrasts in interpretation converging on this point. Rohan Murty, founder of the Murty Classical Library of India and of digital transformation company Soroco, offers us one end in a brilliant essay, at the end of which he charmingly thanks an LLM (large language model) for help in editing. He calls the movement from the internet as we know it to the world of AI as a scaling up from mere information to knowledge. On the other, Urvashi Aneja, founder and executive director of Digital Futures Lab, an interdisciplinary research collective that examines the interaction between technology and society in the Global South, tells us what AI is *not*. "Setting the narrative straight starts with cutting through the hype...AI systems are far from resembling human intelligence. Rather, AI systems are better understood as a form of computational statistics that scan large quantities of data to detect patterns and provide probabilistic analysis or prediction." It is only public oversight, an attuning to the real needs of the people of India, that can make a good thing of this. Srikanth Velamakanni, co-founder of leading AI player Fractal Analytics, puts his finger on what can happen otherwise: the real danger that "those who develop and control these technologies could monopolise benefits, leading to imbalances in global power structures".

Accompanying the essays, we offer you INDIA TODAY's own reckoning with AI: a set of images by Group Creative Editor Nilanjan Das, which he calls "hybrid" art. He says: "I visualised everything, and realised it through AI, with the aid of multiple tools and trained bots. I then finished off manually with other software. Even after detailed prompts, AI first throws up images with no connection whatsoever to what I want to convey. It's like a dumb guy who you have to train, with stories." This is a fascinating snapshot of what the beast is. For the moment, humans still have to hand-hold the future. But it is worthwhile to remember that one cannot halt the march of technology and that revolutions have a nasty habit of devouring their creators.

(Aroon Purie)